



The Lazy Developer

18

MODULE

Marketing Your SaaS Application

Tactics for user acquisition, digital marketing strategies, and growth hacks. Plus a lengthy list of sites where you can launch!

Table of Contents

01. Set up your social media asap! (20 min)
02. Plenty of places to go to launch your app. (22 min)
03. Approach online influencers and creators in your space. (18 min)
04. Go where your users hang out. (20 min)
05. Setup an affiliate program. (18 min)

Set Up Your Social Media ASAP!

Imagine you're opening a new restaurant. You've spent months perfecting the menu, designing the interior, and training the staff. Opening night is still six weeks away. Would you wait until the doors open to tell anyone the restaurant exists? Of course not. You'd be posting construction photos, sneak peeks of the menu, behind-the-scenes clips of the chef experimenting with dishes, and counting down to opening day. By the time you flip that "Open" sign, you'd already have a crowd waiting outside.

Your SaaS app deserves the same treatment. Social media isn't something you "get around to" after launch. It's something you set up the moment you decide to build. Every day you spend building without a social presence is a day you could have been growing an audience of people who are genuinely interested in what you're creating. By the time you're ready to launch, you want followers who already know your name, understand your product, and are excited to try it.

Let's walk through how to set up your social media presence, which platforms to prioritise, what to actually post, and how to use AI to make the whole process dramatically easier.

Why Social Media Matters Before You Launch

Here's the uncomfortable truth about launching a product: if nobody knows about it, nobody will use it. You could build the most incredible app in the world, but without an audience, launch day is just... you refreshing your analytics dashboard alone.

Social media solves this by letting you build in public. Building in public means sharing your journey as you create your product — the wins, the struggles, the progress updates, the design decisions. It's become one of the most powerful marketing strategies in the indie hacker and SaaS community for several reasons:

- People love following a journey. There's something compelling about watching someone build something from scratch. It's reality TV for tech people.
- It builds trust. When people see you being transparent about your process, they trust your product more when it launches.
- It creates accountability. When you share publicly that you're working on something, you're more likely to follow through.
- It generates feedback. Share a screenshot of your UI and people will tell you what works and what doesn't — for free.
- It compounds over time. A post today might get 5 likes. But six months of consistent posting builds an audience that amplifies your launch exponentially.

The indie hacker community — people building small software products independently — has embraced building in public as almost a standard practice. Platforms like Twitter/X are full of founders sharing their Monthly Recurring Revenue (MRR) numbers, their feature releases, and their honest struggles. It works because it's genuine.

Which Platforms Should You Prioritise?

You don't need to be everywhere. In fact, trying to maintain a presence on every platform from day one is a recipe for burnout. Instead, pick two or three platforms that make the most sense for your product and audience, and do those well.

Here's a breakdown of the major platforms and who they work best for:

Platform	Best For	Audience Type	Content Style	Effort Level
Twitter/X	SaaS, dev tools, indie hackers	Tech community, founders, developers	Short text updates, threads, screenshots	Medium
LinkedIn	B2B SaaS, professional tools	Business professionals, decision makers	updates, articles, case studies	Medium
TikTok	Visual products, broad appeal	Gen Z, millennials, general consumers	Short video demos, behind-the-scenes, tips	High (video creation)
Instagram	Design-heavy products, lifestyle	Visual-first audiences, younger demographics	Polished images, Reels, Stories	High (visual content)
YouTube	Technical products, tutorials	People actively searching for solutions	Long-form tutorials, demos, walkthroughs	High (production)
Reddit	Niche communities, technical products	Highly engaged niche communities	Value-first posts, discussions, feedback requests	Low-Medium

Twitter/X — The Indie Hacker Hub

If you're building a SaaS product, Twitter/X is almost certainly your first stop. The indie hacker and tech community there is massive and supportive. People genuinely celebrate others' wins and offer help during struggles. The format — short, punchy posts — is perfect for quick build updates.

What works on Twitter/X:

- Sharing milestones: "Just hit 100 users on my app!"
- Screenshots of features in progress
- Short threads explaining a decision you made
- Engagement posts asking for opinions
- Revenue updates (the community loves transparency)

LinkedIn — The B2B Powerhouse

If your app targets businesses or professionals, LinkedIn is essential. The platform has evolved dramatically — it's no longer just for job hunting. Founders share genuine stories, product updates, and industry insights that get significant engagement. The algorithm currently favours personal stories and lessons learned, which pairs perfectly with a build-in-public approach.

TikTok — The Wild Card That Works

Don't underestimate TikTok for SaaS. Short video demos of your app, behind-the-scenes coding sessions, and quick tips can reach audiences you'd never find on Twitter. We use TikTok ourselves at @TheLazyDeveloper to share quick tips, building sessions, and platform updates. The format forces you to be concise and engaging, which is a great exercise for your marketing messaging overall.

The beauty of TikTok is the algorithm. Unlike Twitter where you need followers to get reach, TikTok will show your video to relevant audiences regardless of your follower count. A single good video can get tens of thousands of views even if you have zero followers.

YouTube — The Long Game

YouTube is a longer-term investment, but it pays dividends. Tutorial videos and product demos live forever on YouTube. Someone might discover your product through a YouTube video you made three years ago. If your product requires explanation or has a learning curve, YouTube is invaluable.

Reddit — The Honest Feedback Machine

Reddit deserves a mention here (and we'll cover it in much more detail in a later section). Subreddits like r/SideProject, r/startups, and r/webdev are great for sharing your progress and getting brutally honest feedback. Just be aware: Reddit communities hate blatant self-promotion. Lead with value, not a sales pitch.

Setting Up Consistent Branding

Before you start posting, take an hour to set up your profiles properly. Consistency across platforms builds recognition and professionalism. Here's your checklist:

Profile Picture: Use the same image or logo across all platforms. If it's a personal brand (common for indie hackers), use a clear, friendly headshot. If it's a company brand, use your logo.

Handle/Username: Try to get the same handle on every platform. If @yourappname is taken, try @yourappnameHQ or @getyourappname. Consistency matters — you want people to find you easily.

Bio: Write a clear, concise bio that explains what your product does and who it's for. Include a link to your website (or landing page, even if it's a simple "coming soon" page).

Banner Image: Use the same banner design across platforms. It should include your app name, a brief tagline, and optionally a screenshot or illustration.

Here's a prompt to get AI to help you set this up:

```
I'm building a SaaS app called [app name] that [describe what it does].  
Help me create consistent social media profiles. Write:  
1. A Twitter/X bio (max 160 characters)  
2. A LinkedIn headline and about section (2-3 sentences)  
3. A TikTok bio (max 80 characters)  
4. A universal tagline I can use across all platforms  
5. Suggestions for my handle if @[appname] is taken
```

What to Actually Post: Your Content Strategy

The biggest mistake people make with social media is treating it like a billboard — just blasting "Buy my product!" over and over. That doesn't work. Instead, think of social media as a conversation. You're sharing your journey, providing value, and building relationships.

Here's a content mix that works well for SaaS builders:

The 70/20/10 Rule

- 70% Value and Journey: Tips, insights, build updates, lessons learned, behind-the-scenes
- 20% Community Engagement: Replying to others, retweeting/sharing, asking questions, running polls
- 10% Promotion: Direct product mentions, feature announcements, launch posts

If you flip this ratio and make 70% of your posts promotional, people will unfollow you fast. The key is that by the time you do promote your product, your audience already trusts you and is interested.

Content Ideas by Category

Build-in-Public Updates

- "Today I implemented [feature]. Here's a quick demo..."
- "Week 12 of building [app name]. Here's what I shipped this week..."
- "I just hit [milestone] users. Here's what I've learned so far..."
- "Honest update: this week was rough. Here's what went wrong and how I fixed it..."

Tips and Value Posts

- Share something you learned that could help others
- Quick how-to threads about your domain (e.g., "5 things I wish I knew about deploying to Railway")
- Recommendations for tools, resources, or approaches you've found useful

Behind-the-Scenes

- Screenshots of your development environment
- Time-lapse videos of you building a feature
- Your workspace setup
- The tech stack you chose and why

Engagement Posts

- "What's the hardest part of [problem your app solves]?"
- Polls: "Which feature should I build next? A or B?"
- "What tools are you using for [relevant topic]?"

User Testimonials and Social Proof

- Share positive feedback (with permission)
- Repost user content that mentions your product
- Case studies of how someone used your product

Posting Frequency and Scheduling

How often should you post? Here's a realistic guide that won't burn you out:

Platform	Minimum Frequency	Ideal Frequency	Best Times
Twitter/X	3x per week	1-2x daily	Morning (8-10am) and evening (5-7pm) your target audience's time zone Tuesday-Thursday, 9-10am Evening hours, weekends
LinkedIn	2x per week	3-5x per week	
TikTok	2x per week	1x daily	
Instagram	2x per week	3-5x per week	Lunch (11am-1pm) and evening (7-9pm) Tuesday-Thursday
YouTube	1x per month	1x per week	

Scheduling Tools

You absolutely do not need to be online every time a post goes out. Use scheduling tools to batch-create content and schedule it in advance:

- Buffer (Free tier: 3 channels, 10 posts per channel): Simple, clean interface. Great for beginners.
- Hootsuite (Free tier: 2 channels): More features but slightly more complex.
- Typefully (Free tier available): Specifically designed for Twitter/X. Great for writing threads.
- Later (Free tier: 1 profile per platform): Particularly good for Instagram with visual planning.
- Native scheduling: Twitter/X, LinkedIn, and YouTube all have built-in scheduling for free.

A good workflow is to spend one or two hours on a Sunday batch-creating your posts for the week, schedule them all, and then just check in during the week to respond to comments and engage with others.

Using AI to Generate Social Content

This is where things get really powerful. AI tools can help you create social media content dramatically faster. Instead of staring at a blank screen trying to think of what to post, you can use prompts to generate ideas and drafts in seconds.

Here's a practical prompt you can use right now:

Write 10 Twitter/X posts announcing the launch of my SaaS app [describe your app – what it does, who it's for, what problem it solves].

Mix between:

- 3 feature highlight posts
- 3 behind-the-scenes/build journey posts
- 2 engagement questions
- 2 social proof or milestone posts

Keep each post under 280 characters. Use a conversational, excited but not salesy tone. Include relevant hashtags where appropriate.

And here's another for creating a week's worth of content:

Create a 7-day social media content calendar for my SaaS app [describe app]. For each day, provide:

- A Twitter/X post (under 280 characters)
- A LinkedIn post (2-3 paragraphs, professional tone)
- A TikTok video concept (30-60 seconds, describe the script and visual)

Follow the 70/20/10 rule: 70% value/journey, 20% engagement, 10% promotion. The tone should be friendly and authentic, not corporate.

For visual content, you can also use AI to help plan your graphics:

I need to create 5 social media graphics for my SaaS app [describe app].

Suggest:

1. What each graphic should show (feature screenshot, comparison, stat, etc.)
2. A headline for each graphic (max 8 words)
3. A supporting caption for each platform (Twitter, LinkedIn, Instagram)
4. Colour palette suggestions that match my brand colours [list your colours]

The Build-in-Public Playbook

Let's get specific about building in public, because it's genuinely one of the most effective marketing strategies for indie SaaS products.

Phase 1: Pre-Development (Weeks before you write code)

- Share the problem you're going to solve
- Post about your research process
- Ask your audience what features they'd want
- Share competitor analysis (respectfully)

Phase 2: Active Development

- Weekly progress updates
- Feature demos (even if rough)
- Tech stack decisions and why you made them
- Bugs you encountered and how you fixed them
- Revenue: \$0 — and that's okay, share anyway

Phase 3: Pre-Launch

- Teaser posts and countdowns
- Early access or beta invites for followers
- Behind-the-scenes of your launch preparation
- Ask for help: "Can anyone with [specific expertise] give me feedback?"

Phase 4: Launch and Beyond

- The launch announcement (we'll cover launch platforms in the next section)
- User testimonials and early feedback
- Revenue milestones
- Feature updates and roadmap sharing
- Lessons learned posts

Platform-Specific Tips

Twitter/X Tips

- Threads perform well. A thread that walks through your journey or explains something valuable will get more reach than a single tweet.
- Quote tweet with your take when sharing relevant industry news.
- Engage before you post. Spend 10 minutes replying to others in your niche before publishing your own content. The algorithm rewards active users.
- Pin your best tweet — make it your app announcement or a popular thread.

LinkedIn Tips

- Start with a hook. LinkedIn truncates posts after about 3 lines. Your first sentence needs to grab attention.
- Use line breaks liberally. Dense paragraphs get scrolled past. Short lines with space between them get read.
- Personal stories outperform corporate updates. "I almost gave up on my app last Tuesday" will outperform "We're excited to announce feature X."
- Comment on posts by people in your target market. Thoughtful comments get you visible to their audience.

TikTok Tips

- Show, don't tell. Screen recordings of your app with a voiceover explaining what's happening work brilliantly.
- Use trending sounds when they fit — it massively boosts discoverability.
- Hook in the first second. Start with the most interesting part: "I built this in 3 hours using AI" is better than "So today I want to talk about my app..."
- Keep it under 60 seconds for best performance. Under 30 seconds is even better for new accounts.

Measuring What Works

Don't post blindly. Every platform provides analytics that show you what's working. Check them weekly and double down on what resonates.

Key metrics to track:

Metric	What It Tells You	Where to Find It
Impressions	How many people saw your post	Native analytics on each platform
Engagement Rate	How many people interacted (likes, comments, shares) relative to views	Native analytics
Profile Visits	How many people clicked through to your profile after seeing a post	Native analytics
Link Clicks	How many people clicked through to your website or app	Link tracking tools (Bitly, UTM parameters)
Follower Growth	Is your audience growing over time?	Native analytics

The most important metric early on is engagement rate, not follower count. Having 200 engaged followers who comment and share is infinitely more valuable than 10,000 followers who never interact.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

1. Waiting until launch to start posting. Start now. Even if your app is just an idea on a napkin.
2. Being too promotional. Follow the 70/20/10 rule. Nobody wants to follow an advertisement.
3. Posting inconsistently. Three posts in one day then nothing for two weeks is worse than one post every three days.
4. Ignoring comments and DMs. Social media is social. Respond to people who engage with you.
5. Trying to be on every platform at once. Pick two or three and do them well.
6. Copying competitor content. Be authentic. People can spot inauthenticity instantly.
7. Using AI-generated content without editing. AI is a starting point. Always add your personal voice and specifics before publishing.

Key Takeaways

- Start your social media presence before you write a single line of code. The earlier you begin building an audience, the bigger your launch will be.
- Pick 2-3 platforms that match your audience. Twitter/X is almost always essential for SaaS. Add LinkedIn for B2B, TikTok for visual/broad appeal, or YouTube for technical products.
- Set up consistent branding across all platforms. Same profile picture, same handle (or as close as possible), clear bio with a link to your site.
- Follow the 70/20/10 content rule. 70% value and journey sharing, 20% community engagement, 10% direct promotion.
- Build in public. Share your progress, your wins, your struggles, and your milestones. People love following a genuine journey.
- Use scheduling tools to batch-create content. Spend a couple of hours on the weekend, schedule the week, then just engage during the week.
- Leverage AI for content creation. Use prompts to generate post ideas, drafts, content calendars, and graphic concepts. Always edit and personalise before posting.
- Measure and adapt. Check your analytics weekly. Do more of what's working. Engagement rate matters more than follower count, especially early on.
- Respond and engage. Social media rewards people who are genuinely social. Reply to comments, engage with others' posts, and build real relationships.

Plenty of Places to Go to Launch Your App

Think of launching your app like opening night of a play. You've rehearsed for months, the set is built, the costumes are ready. But if you only invited your mum and your best friend, that beautiful theatre is going to feel pretty empty. A successful opening night needs a full house — and that means getting the word out to every relevant audience you can find.

The same is true for your SaaS launch. Your product might be brilliant, but if you only share it on your personal Twitter account and hope for the best, you're leaving an enormous amount of potential on the table. The good news? There are dozens of platforms specifically designed for product launches, and many of them are completely free. The even better news? You don't need to launch on all of them on the same day. You can stagger your launches over weeks or even months, getting a fresh wave of attention each time.

In this section, we'll walk through a comprehensive list of launch platforms, give you specific tips for the most important ones, and build a launch strategy that maximises your visibility without burning you out.

The Marathon Mindset: Why Launch Day Is Just the Beginning

Before we dive into the platforms, let's reframe what "launching" actually means. Many first-time builders think of launch as a single, make-or-break event. You post on Product Hunt, hold your breath, and either it works or it doesn't. That's a lot of pressure — and it's the wrong way to think about it.

In reality, the most successful products launch multiple times across multiple platforms over several weeks. Each platform is a new audience that's never heard of you. What feels repetitive to you is brand new to them.

Here's a healthier way to think about it:

- Week 1: Soft launch to your existing audience (social media, email list)
- Week 2: Product Hunt launch
- Week 3: Reddit, Hacker News, Indie Hackers
- Week 4: BetaList, directory submissions, blog posts
- Ongoing: New platforms, communities, guest posts, and partnerships

Each of these is a mini-launch. Each brings new eyes. And each gives you an opportunity to refine your messaging based on what resonated before.

The Comprehensive Launch Platform Guide

Let's go through the major platforms where you can launch your product. For each one, we'll cover what it is, who the audience is, what works, and any specific tips.

Product Hunt

What it is: The most well-known product launch platform. Products are featured daily, upvoted by the community, and the top products each day get significant visibility.

Audience: Tech enthusiasts, early adopters, founders, investors, and product managers.

Cost: Free to launch.

Why it matters: A successful Product Hunt launch can drive hundreds or thousands of visitors to your site in a single day. It also provides social proof — "Featured on Product Hunt" is a badge many SaaS products display proudly.

Tips for a successful Product Hunt launch:

- Pick your day carefully. Avoid launching on Mondays (everyone launches on Monday) and weekends (lower traffic). Tuesday through Thursday tend to be the sweet spot.
- Launch at 12:01 AM Pacific Time. Product Hunt resets daily at midnight Pacific. Launching right at the start gives you the full 24 hours to accumulate upvotes.
- Find a Hunter. While you can launch your own product, having a well-known community member "hunt" (submit) your product can boost visibility. Reach out to active hunters beforehand.
- Write a compelling tagline. You get about 60 characters. Make it crystal clear what your product does and why someone should care.
- Prepare your Maker Comment. As the maker, your first comment on the launch should introduce yourself, explain why you built this, what problem it solves, and invite questions. Be genuine and personal.
- Rally your network (authentically). Let your followers, friends, and community know about the launch. Ask them to check it out and leave honest feedback — not just "please upvote." Product Hunt's algorithm detects inauthentic voting patterns.
- Prepare visuals. High-quality screenshots, a demo video (GIF or short video), and a clear logo make your listing stand out.

Here's a prompt to help you prepare:

```
Write a Product Hunt launch description for my app [describe your app].  
Include:  
1. A tagline (max 60 characters)  
2. A description (2-3 short paragraphs)  
3. A maker's first comment (personal, genuine, 3-4 paragraphs)  
4. 5 key features as bullet points  
5. 3 thumbnail/screenshot descriptions that would showcase the app well
```

Hacker News (Show HN)

What it is: The legendary tech community run by Y Combinator. "Show HN" is a dedicated format for sharing projects you've built.

Audience: Developers, technical founders, engineers, and tech enthusiasts. This is a very technically savvy crowd.

Cost: Free.

What works: Technical depth, unique approaches, honest stories about your building journey, and genuine innovation. Hacker News values substance over marketing polish.

What doesn't work: Marketing-speak, buzzword-heavy descriptions, or anything that feels like an advertisement. The community will downvote you into oblivion if you come across as salesy.

Tips:

- Title format: "Show HN: [Product Name] – [What It Does in Plain English]"
- Include a text comment explaining the backstory, the tech stack, and what makes it interesting
- Be prepared for tough feedback. HN commenters are brilliant but direct. Take it constructively.
- Respond to every comment thoughtfully. Engagement matters.

Reddit

What it is: A massive network of topic-specific communities (subreddits). Several subreddits are perfect for product launches.

Audience: Varies by subreddit. Highly engaged, often sceptical of self-promotion.

Relevant subreddits:

- [r/SideProject](#) — Built specifically for people sharing their side projects. Very supportive community.
- [r/webdev](#) — For web development projects. Share your tech journey, not just your product.
- [r/startups](#) — For startup founders. Good for sharing milestones and asking for feedback.
- [r/InternetIsBeautiful](#) — For visually impressive or particularly clever web applications.
- [r/alphaandbetausers](#) — People looking to try new products and give feedback.
- [r/EntrepreneurRideAlong](#) — For founders building businesses. Share your journey.

The golden rule: Reddit communities have strict rules about self-promotion. Read the rules of each subreddit before posting. Lead with value — share what you learned building it, ask for genuine feedback, or tell an interesting story. Don't just post "Check out my app!"

Indie Hackers

What it is: A community of founders building profitable internet businesses. Founded by Courtland Allen, it's one of the most supportive communities for indie SaaS builders.

Audience: Solo founders, indie hackers, bootstrapped SaaS builders.

Cost: Free.

What works: Transparency about revenue, honest build stories, milestone posts, and asking for feedback. The community celebrates small wins just as much as big ones.

Tips:

- Create a product page for your app on Indie Hackers
- Post milestone updates ("Just hit \$100 MRR!" or "First 50 users!")
- Share detailed build stories — the community loves hearing about the journey
- Engage with other people's posts too — it's a community, not a billboard

BetaList

What it is: A platform specifically for pre-launch products looking for early adopters and beta testers.

Audience: Early adopters who love trying new products before they're widely available.

Cost: Free submission (can take weeks to be featured) or paid (\$129+) for faster, guaranteed listing.

When to use it: Before your official launch. BetaList is perfect for building an email list of interested users before you're fully ready.

AlternativeTo

What it is: A website where users discover alternatives to popular software. If your product competes with or is an alternative to an established tool, this is gold.

Audience: People actively searching for alternatives to existing tools — high purchase intent.

Cost: Free to list.

Tips: Position your product clearly as an alternative to well-known competitors. Explain what makes yours different or better for certain use cases.

There's An AI For That (TAAFT)

What it is: A directory of AI-powered tools. If your product uses AI in any way, this is a must-list platform.

Audience: People looking for AI solutions to specific problems.

Cost: Free to submit.

Tips: Be specific about what AI capabilities your product offers. The directory is searchable, so use clear, descriptive language.

Additional Platforms Worth Listing On

Platform	What It Is	Audience	Cost	Best For
SaaSHub	SaaS discovery platform	People comparing SaaS tools	Free	Established SaaS products
MicroLaunch	Launch platform for micro-SaaS	Indie hackers, small SaaS builders	Free	Small, focused products
Launching.io	Product launch community	Founders and early adopters	Free	New product launches
SideProjectors	Marketplace for side projects	Developers, buyers, collaborators	Free	Side projects
Dev.to	Developer blogging platform	Developers and tech enthusiasts	Free	seeking users or technical build stories and tutorials
Hashnode	Developer blogging platform	Developers with personal blogs	Free	Technical content that drives traffic
Uneed	Curated product directory	Tech early adopters	Free	Quality products seeking visibility
Peerlist	Professional network for builders	Developers, designers, founders	Free	Portfolio and project showcases
ToolPilot.ai	AI tool directory	AI tool seekers	Free	AI-powered products
StartupStash	Curated directory of startup resources	Founders looking for tools	Free/Paid	SaaS tools for startups

Your Pre-Launch Checklist

Before you start posting on these platforms, make sure you have everything ready. There's nothing worse than driving a flood of traffic to a broken sign-up flow.

Technical readiness:

- Landing page is live and loads fast
- Sign-up or waitlist form works perfectly
- Analytics are set up (you want to track where visitors come from)
- The app itself is stable and usable (it doesn't need to be perfect, but it needs to work)

Marketing materials:

- Clear, concise description of what your product does (one sentence, one paragraph, and three paragraphs)
- High-quality screenshots (at least 3-5)
- Demo video or GIF (30-90 seconds)
- Logo in multiple sizes
- Tagline (under 60 characters)
- Feature list (5-7 key features)

Social proof (if you have any):

- Beta user testimonials
- Usage statistics ("500 users in our beta")
- Notable mentions or press

Here's a prompt to help you prepare all of this:

```
I'm preparing to launch my SaaS app [describe app] on Product Hunt,
Hacker News, Reddit, and Indie Hackers over the next month.
Help me create a launch kit with:

1. A one-sentence description
2. A one-paragraph description
3. A three-paragraph description
4. A tagline (under 60 characters)
5. 7 key features as bullet points
6. 5 screenshot descriptions (what should each screenshot show?)
7. A 60-second demo video script
8. 3 different post titles optimised for: Product Hunt, Hacker News (Show HN), and
Reddit (r...
```

Post-Launch Follow-Up Strategy

The launch itself is only half the battle. What you do in the hours and days after you launch is equally important.

In the first 24 hours:

- Respond to every comment on every platform
- Thank people who share your product
- Fix any bugs that users report (immediately)
- Share updates on your social media about the launch progress

In the first week:

- Write a "launch retrospective" post — what went well, what you'd change, traffic numbers, sign-up numbers. These posts do incredibly well on Twitter/X, LinkedIn, and Indie Hackers.
- Follow up with everyone who provided feedback
- Send a thank-you email to beta users and early supporters

In the first month:

- Continue staggered launches on remaining platforms
- Write guest blog posts about your building journey
- Reach out to newsletter authors who cover new products in your space
- Update your product based on the feedback you received

Timing Your Launches for Maximum Impact

Not all days and times are equal when it comes to launching. Here's a general guide:

Platform	Best Day	Best Time	Why
Product Hunt	Tuesday-Thursday	12:01 AM Pacific	Full 24 hours, avoids Monday/weekend
Hacker News	Weekday mornings	8-10 AM Eastern	Peak traffic for the US tech crowd
Reddit	Tuesday-Thursday	9 AM - 12 PM in relevant timezone	Highest engagement mid-week
Indie Hackers	Any weekday	Morning	Community is active during working hours
BetaList	Submit 2-3 weeks before planned launch	N/A	Takes time to be reviewed and featured

Learning From Every Launch

Each platform you launch on is a learning opportunity. Track these metrics for each launch:

- Traffic: How many visitors did this platform send? (Use UTM parameters in your links to track this in Google Analytics)
- Sign-ups: How many of those visitors actually signed up?
- Conversion rate: Traffic to sign-ups — this tells you how compelling your landing page is
- Engagement: How many comments, upvotes, or shares did you get?
- Feedback quality: Did you get actionable feedback you can use to improve?

Over time, you'll learn which platforms work best for your specific product and audience. Double down on those.

Key Takeaways

- Launch is a marathon, not a sprint. Stagger your launches across multiple platforms over several weeks. Each platform is a fresh audience.
- Product Hunt is the biggest stage, but it requires preparation. Pick the right day (Tuesday-Thursday), launch at midnight Pacific, prepare your maker comment, and rally your network authentically.
- Hacker News values substance. Skip the marketing polish and lead with technical depth, honest stories, and genuine innovation.
- Reddit requires a value-first approach. Read each subreddit's rules, lead with your story or learnings, and avoid blatant self-promotion.
- Indie Hackers is your tribe. The community celebrates transparency, small wins, and honest build stories. Create a product page and share milestone updates.
- Prepare a launch kit before you launch anywhere. Descriptions at three lengths, screenshots, a demo video, and a clear feature list will serve you across all platforms.
- Follow up after every launch. Respond to comments, fix reported bugs immediately, and write a retrospective. The follow-up often generates more long-term value than the launch itself.
- Track everything. Use UTM parameters and analytics to understand which platforms drive the most valuable traffic for your specific product.

- Use AI to prepare your launch materials. Prompts can help you write descriptions, taglines, maker comments, and post titles for every platform. Always personalise the output before posting.

Approach Online Influencers and Creators in Your Space

Think about the last time you bought something online. Maybe it was a piece of software, a course, or a physical product. There's a good chance you didn't find it through an advertisement. You probably heard about it from someone you follow — a YouTuber you trust, a Twitter account whose opinions you respect, or a newsletter writer whose recommendations you've acted on before. That's the power of influencer marketing: it's word of mouth at scale, delivered through voices that already have your target audience's attention and trust.

For SaaS products — especially those built by indie hackers and solo founders — influencer marketing is one of the most cost-effective acquisition channels available. You don't need a massive advertising budget. You don't need a marketing team. You need genuine relationships with the right creators, a product worth talking about, and a smart approach to outreach.

In this section, we'll cover how to find relevant creators, how to approach them without being spammy, what to offer in exchange for coverage, and how to measure whether it's actually working.

Why Influencer Marketing Works for SaaS

Before we get into tactics, let's understand why this approach is particularly effective for software products.

Trust transfer: When a creator recommends your product, their audience transfers a portion of the trust they have in that creator onto your product. This is far more powerful than any ad campaign. An ad says "we're great" — but a trusted creator saying "I tried this and it's genuinely good" carries real weight.

Targeted reach: The right creator already has the exact audience you're trying to reach. Instead of casting a wide net with ads and hoping your target customers are in there somewhere, you're putting your product directly in front of people who are predisposed to care about it.

Content creation: When a creator reviews your product, they're creating marketing content for you — often higher quality and more authentic than anything you'd produce yourself. That YouTube review, that Twitter thread, that newsletter mention — these are assets that continue working for you long after the initial publication.

SEO and backlinks: Blog posts and YouTube videos that mention your product create backlinks and search visibility that can drive traffic for months or years.

Finding the Right Creators

The key word here is "right." Having a creator with 5 million followers mention your niche project management tool won't do much if their audience is primarily interested in gaming. You want creators whose audience overlaps significantly with your target users.

Here's where to look:

YouTube Tech Reviewers and Tutorial Creators

YouTube is gold for SaaS products because video reviews and tutorials are incredibly persuasive. People watch someone actually use your product and see it in action.

Search YouTube for:

- "[your problem space] tools" (e.g., "best project management tools 2026")
- "[competitor name] alternatives"
- "[your industry] software review"
- "build with [technology your audience uses]"

Look for creators with 5,000 to 100,000 subscribers. These "mid-tier" creators often have highly engaged audiences and are much more likely to respond to outreach than someone with millions of subscribers.

Twitter/X Tech Voices

The tech Twitter community is full of people who regularly share tool recommendations, build-in-public updates, and product reviews. Look for:

- Indie hackers with engaged followings
- Tech bloggers and newsletter writers
- Developers who share tool recommendations
- Founders in adjacent (not competing) spaces

Newsletter Writers

Email newsletters have some of the highest engagement rates of any medium. A recommendation in a relevant newsletter can drive a surge of high-quality traffic. Look for newsletters in your space using:

- Substack's discover page
- Newsletter directories like LetterList
- Searching "[your niche] newsletter" on Google

Podcast Hosts

If there are podcasts in your space, a guest appearance or sponsor mention can reach a dedicated audience. Podcast listeners are often more engaged than users on visual platforms because they've chosen to spend 30-60 minutes on the topic.

TikTok and Instagram Creators

For more consumer-facing or visual products, short-form video creators on TikTok and Instagram can generate significant buzz. Look for creators who already make content about productivity, tech tools, or whatever category fits your product.

Micro-Influencers vs Macro-Influencers

One of the biggest decisions in influencer marketing is whether to work with a few big names or many smaller creators. For most SaaS products — especially early-stage ones — micro-influencers are the clear winner.

Factor	Micro-Influencers (1K-50K followers)	Macro-Influencers (50K-500K+ followers)
Cost	Often free (product access) or very affordable (\$50-\$500)	Expensive (\$1,000-\$10,000+)
Engagement Rate	Higher (3-8% typical)	Lower (1-3% typical)
Audience Trust	Very high — followers feel a personal connection	Moderate — more "celebrity" feel
Conversion Rate	Higher — recommendations feel genuine	Lower — can feel like sponsored content
Response to Outreach	Much more likely to respond and collaborate	Often require going through management
Content Quality	Authentic, personal	Polished, professional
Best For	Early-stage products, niche audiences	Brand awareness, broad reach

The math often works out like this: ten micro-influencers, each with 5,000 engaged followers in your niche, will generate more sign-ups than one macro-influencer with 500,000 followers who aren't specifically your target audience.

How to Approach Creators (Without Being Spammy)

This is where most people get it wrong. They send a generic message to 100 creators and wonder why nobody responds. The secret is personalisation and genuine value.

The Wrong Way

"Hi! I built an amazing app and I think your audience would love it. Can you review it? Here's the link: [link]"

This gets deleted instantly. It says nothing about why you chose this specific creator, shows no knowledge of their content, and only focuses on what you want.

The Right Way

Before reaching out to any creator:

1. Follow them for at least a week. Engage with their content genuinely.
2. Leave thoughtful comments on their posts or videos.
3. Understand their content style and what their audience cares about.
4. Find a genuine connection between their content and your product.

Then, when you reach out:

Cold DM Template (Twitter/X):

Hey [Name], I've been following your content on [specific topic] for a while – your [specific post/video] about [topic] really resonated with me.

I'm building [product name], which [one sentence about what it does]. I think it could be really relevant to your audience who are interested in [topic they cover].

Would you be open to trying it out? Happy to give you full access, no strings attached. If you like it and think it's worth sharing, amazing. If not, I'd genuinely appreciate any feedback.

Either way, keep making great content!

Email Outreach Template:

Subject: Loved your [specific content piece] – quick thought

Hi [Name],

I'm [your name], and I've been a regular [reader/viewer/listener] of your [newsletter/channel/podcast]. Your recent piece on [specific topic] was especially good – [specific detail showing you actually consumed the content].

I'm reaching out because I've been building [product name], a [one sentence description]. Given your audience's interest in [their niche], I thought there might be a natural fit.

I'd love to offer you:

- Full free access to [product name] (no time limit)
- A personal walkthrough if you'd find that helpful
- [Any other specific offer]

No pressure to cover it – I genuinely think you'd find it useful yourself. But if you do think it's worth mentioning to your audience, I'd be thrilled.

Happy to answer any questions. Thanks for all the great content you put out!

Best,

[Your name]

[Your website]

Here's a prompt to personalise your outreach at scale:

Draft 3 personalised outreach emails to YouTube tech creators asking them to review my SaaS product [describe your product, what it does, who it's for].

For each email, I'll give you the creator's details:

- Creator 1: [Name, channel name, recent video topic, subscriber count]
- Creator 2: [Name, channel name, recent video topic, subscriber count]
- Creator 3: [Name, channel name, recent video topic, subscriber count]

Each email should:

- Reference their specific content genuinely
- Explain why my product is relevant to their audience
- Offer something of value (free access, exclusive deal for their audience)
- Feel personal, not templated
- Be under 200 words

What to Offer Creators

Different creators respond to different incentives. Here are the most common approaches, from lowest to highest cost:

Free access to your product: The simplest offer. Give them a premium account at no cost. Many creators genuinely enjoy trying new tools and will share if they like it.

Exclusive discount for their audience: Provide a unique coupon code (e.g., "CREATOR20" for 20% off). This gives the creator something special to offer their audience and lets you track which creator drives sign-ups.

Affiliate commission: Offer a percentage of revenue from customers they refer. This aligns incentives — they earn more when they drive real results. We'll cover affiliate programs in detail in a later section.

Sponsorship fee: Pay a flat fee for a dedicated mention, review, or integration. This is more common with larger creators and gives you more control over the messaging.

Co-creation: Build something together. Maybe they name a feature, or you create a template inspired by their workflow. This creates genuine investment in your product's success.

Offer Type	Cost	Creator Appeal	Your Control	Best For
Free access	Zero	Moderate	Low	Any stage, initial outreach
Exclusive discount	Revenue share	High (value for their audience)	Medium	Growing products
Affiliate commission	Performance-based	High (ongoing income)	Low	Products with proven conversion
Sponsorship	Fixed fee (\$100-\$5,000+)	Very high	High	Established products with strategic budget
Co-creation	Time investment	Very high	Shared	partnerships

Building Genuine Relationships

The most successful influencer marketing doesn't feel like marketing at all. It feels like a genuine recommendation from someone who actually uses and likes your product.

Here's how to build those genuine relationships:

- Engage with their content consistently, not just when you want something.
- Share their content with your audience.
- Provide value to them beyond your product — introductions, feedback on their projects, etc.
- Don't expect immediate results. Some relationships take months before they lead to a mention.
- Accept "no" gracefully. If a creator isn't interested, thank them and move on. Never be pushy.
- Follow through on promises. If you said you'd give them free access, do it immediately. If you said you'd fix a bug they found, fix it fast.

Think of it as making friends in your industry, not running a marketing campaign. The best partnerships happen when both sides genuinely benefit.

Measuring ROI from Influencer Campaigns

You need to know whether your influencer efforts are actually driving results. Here's how to track it:

UTM parameters: Give each creator a unique link with UTM tags so you can see exactly how much traffic and how many sign-ups they drive.

Example: `https://yourapp.com?utm_source=youtube&utm_medium=influencer&utm_campaign=creator_name`

Unique discount codes: Each creator gets a unique code. You can track how many times each code is used.

Direct attribution: Ask new sign-ups "How did you hear about us?" in your onboarding flow. You'd be surprised how many people will say "I saw it on [creator]'s video."

Traffic spikes: Monitor your analytics around the time a creator publishes content about you. The correlation is usually obvious.

Metric	How to Track	What It Tells You
Traffic	UTM parameters + Google Analytics	How many visitors the creator sent
Sign-ups	UTM tracking or unique landing pages	How many visitors converted to users
Revenue	Discount codes or affiliate tracking	Direct revenue from the partnership
Content value	Manual assessment	Quality and longevity of the content created

Using AI to Research and Plan Outreach

AI can dramatically speed up your influencer research and outreach preparation:

```
I'm looking for YouTube creators who make content about  
[your niche/topic]. My SaaS product is [describe product].  
Help me:  
1. Identify 10 types of YouTube channels that would be relevant  
2. Suggest search queries I should use to find these creators  
3. Create a scoring rubric to evaluate which creators to  
   prioritise (engagement rate, audience relevance, content quality)  
4. Draft a spreadsheet template to track my outreach efforts
```

And for drafting outreach messages:

```
I want to reach out to a tech newsletter writer who covers  
[topic]. Their newsletter has about [subscriber count] subscribers  
and they recently wrote about [specific article topic].  
  
My product is [describe product]. Draft a personalised outreach  
email that:  
- References their recent article naturally  
- Explains why my product is relevant to their readers  
- Offers free access and an exclusive discount for their audience  
- Is warm and genuine, not corporate  
- Is under 150 words
```

Key Takeaways

- Influencer marketing is word of mouth at scale. A trusted creator's recommendation carries more weight than any advertisement you could buy.
- Micro-influencers beat macro-influencers for SaaS. Ten creators with 5,000 engaged, niche followers will typically outperform one creator with 500,000 general followers.
- Personalisation is everything. Generic outreach gets deleted. Reference specific content, explain why you chose them specifically, and offer genuine value.
- Offer a range of incentives. Start with free product access, add exclusive discount codes for their audience, and consider affiliate commissions for ongoing partnerships.
- Build genuine relationships, not transactions. Engage with creators' content consistently, share their work, and provide value beyond your product. The best partnerships feel like friendships.
- Always measure results. Use UTM parameters, unique discount codes, and direct attribution to track which creator partnerships drive real sign-ups and revenue.

- Use AI to scale your research and outreach. AI can help you identify relevant creators, draft personalised messages, and plan your outreach strategy — but always add a personal touch before hitting send.
- Accept that not every creator will say yes. That's perfectly fine. Be gracious, keep building relationships, and focus your energy on the partnerships that do materialise.

Go Where Your Users Hang Out

Imagine you invented the world's best fishing rod. It's lightweight, virtually unbreakable, and catches fish twice as fast as anything else on the market. Now imagine you set up a stall to sell it — in the middle of a shopping mall, surrounded by clothing stores and phone repair shops. You might sell a few to curious passers-by, but you'd sell a thousand times more if you set up that stall at a lakeside, a fishing tournament, or outside a bait shop. The product hasn't changed. The audience has.

This is one of the most fundamental principles in marketing, and it's especially critical for SaaS products: you need to go where your users already congregate. Not where you wish they were, not where the biggest crowds are, but where the specific people who have the problem your product solves are already having conversations, asking questions, and looking for solutions.

In this section, we'll map out the landscape of online communities where your potential users hang out, show you how to engage authentically (without getting banned for self-promotion), and build a community-led growth strategy that turns you from an outsider into a trusted member who happens to have built something useful.

Understanding Your Target Audience

Before you start joining every Discord server and subreddit you can find, take a step back and get specific about who your users actually are. The more precisely you can describe your ideal user, the more effectively you can find them.

Ask yourself these questions:

- What is the specific problem my product solves? Not the general category, but the specific pain point.
- Who experiences this problem most acutely? What's their job title, their industry, their skill level?
- Where do they go when they have questions about this problem? Google? Reddit? A specific forum?
- What other tools do they currently use? Those tools' communities might be where your users hang out.
- What content do they consume? Podcasts, YouTube channels, newsletters, blogs?

Here's a prompt to help you think this through:

```
I've built a SaaS app that [describe what your app does and who it's for].  
Help me create a detailed ideal customer profile:  
1. Demographics (age range, profession, technical skill level)  
2. The specific pain points they experience  
3. The exact words and phrases they would use to describe their problem  
4. Where they go online for help (specific platforms, communities, forums)  
5. What other tools they currently use to solve or work around this problem  
6. What content they consume (blogs, podcasts, YouTube channels, newsletters)
```

Once you have this profile, finding the right communities becomes much more targeted.

The Landscape of Online Communities

Let's walk through the major types of online communities and how each one works for finding and engaging with potential users.

Discord Servers

Discord has exploded beyond gaming and become a hub for every kind of community — tech, design, business, productivity, creativity, and more. Many SaaS tools, coding communities, and industry groups have active Discord servers with thousands of members.

How to find relevant servers:

- Search on Disboard.org or Discord.me (server discovery platforms)
- Look for Discord links on the websites of tools your target users use
- Search Twitter/X for "[your niche] Discord"
- Check if competitors or adjacent products have Discord communities

How to engage:

- Introduce yourself in the #introductions channel (most servers have one)
- Spend your first week just listening and understanding the culture
- Start by answering questions others ask — be genuinely helpful
- Share your product only when it's directly relevant to someone's question, and always with context, not just a link
- Become a recognisable, helpful member before you ever mention your own product

Slack Communities

Many professional communities run on Slack. These tend to be more business-focused and have a higher concentration of decision-makers.

Notable communities:

- Online Geniuses — Digital marketing professionals

- Launch House — Founders and startup builders
- Demand Curve — Growth marketing
- Product-Led Alliance — Product-led growth professionals
- Various industry-specific Slack groups

How to find them: Search "[your industry] Slack community" on Google. Many require an application or invitation, which actually makes them more valuable because the members are more committed.

Facebook Groups

Don't write off Facebook Groups just because Facebook feels "old." Many niche communities on Facebook are incredibly active with highly engaged members, particularly in non-tech industries.

How to find them: Search Facebook for groups related to your product's problem space. Sort by member count and activity level. Groups with 1,000-50,000 members tend to have the best engagement — big enough to be useful, small enough that your contributions are visible.

Subreddits (Reddit Communities)

Reddit is one of the best places to find people discussing specific problems in incredible detail. For almost every niche, there's a subreddit.

How to find relevant subreddits:

- Use Reddit's search to find discussions about your problem space
- Check the sidebar of subreddits you find — they often link to related communities
- Use tools like subredditstats.com to find active communities

Engagement strategy for Reddit:

Do	Don't
Provide thorough, helpful answers to questions	Drop links to your product without context
Share your expertise and experience	Use multiple accounts to upvote yourself
Participate in discussions unrelated to your product	Post the same promotional content across multiple subreddits
Build karma and reputation over weeks before mentioning your product	Argue with people who criticise self-promotion
Be transparent — say "I'm the founder of X" when relevant	Pretend to be a regular user recommending your own product

Forums and Discourse Communities

Many niche communities run on forum software like Discourse. These tend to be more focused and have deeper, longer-form discussions than social media platforms.

Examples:

- Product-specific forums (many SaaS tools have their own Discourse community)
- Industry forums (web development, design, marketing, etc.)

- The Indie Hackers forum (technically Discourse-based)

Stack Overflow and Quora

If your product solves a technical problem, Stack Overflow is where developers go to ask questions. If your product solves a broader problem, Quora is where curious people go for answers.

Strategy: Find questions that relate to the problem your product solves. Write genuinely helpful, detailed answers. If your product is relevant, mention it at the end as one of several options — never as the sole answer.

The Golden Rule: Provide Value First, Promote Second

This principle is so important that it deserves its own section. Every online community has a finely tuned sense of when someone is being genuinely helpful versus when someone is trying to sell something. If you show up in a community and immediately start talking about your product, you'll be ignored at best and banned at worst.

The approach that works is the give, give, give, ask model:

1. Give: Answer someone's question thoroughly
2. Give: Share a useful resource or tip
3. Give: Provide feedback on someone else's project
4. Ask: When someone asks a question that your product directly solves, mention it naturally alongside your helpful answer

Here's what this looks like in practice. Imagine you've built a tool that helps small businesses create invoices:

Bad approach: "Hey everyone! I just launched InvoiceMagic, the best invoicing tool for small businesses! Check it out at [link]!"

Good approach: Someone asks "What's the easiest way to handle invoicing for my freelance business?" You respond with a detailed answer explaining different approaches — spreadsheets, free templates, dedicated software. You mention the pros and cons of each. And at the end, you say: "Full disclosure, I recently built a tool called InvoiceMagic that focuses specifically on this problem for freelancers. But honestly, for someone just starting out, a simple Google Sheets template might be all you need. Here's a link to a free template I like: [link]. If you outgrow that, feel free to check out what I built or other tools like FreshBooks or Wave."

See the difference? The second approach is genuinely helpful, transparent, and positions your product as one option among many rather than a hard sell.

Community-Led Growth Strategy

Community-led growth is a systematic approach to using community engagement as a primary driver of user acquisition. Here's a framework you can follow:

Phase 1: Research and Join (Week 1-2)

- Identify 5-10 communities where your target users are active
- Join each one with a genuine profile
- Read posts for a full week before engaging
- Note the culture, rules, and what types of content get the most engagement

Phase 2: Contribute and Build Reputation (Week 3-6)

- Answer at least 3-5 questions per week across your communities
- Share useful resources (not your own product)
- Engage in discussions — add your perspective and experience
- Start recognising regular members and building relationships

Phase 3: Naturally Introduce Your Product (Week 6+)

- When directly relevant questions come up, mention your product alongside helpful context
- Share your building journey in communities that welcome it (Indie Hackers, r/SideProject)
- Offer free access to community members for feedback
- Create content specifically for the community (a tutorial, a guide, a comparison)

Phase 4: Sustain and Scale

- Continue providing value even after you've gained users
- Consider creating helpful resources specifically for these communities
- If appropriate, build your own community (more on this below)

Writing Helpful Content That Naturally Leads to Your Product

One of the most effective community marketing strategies is creating genuinely useful content that naturally demonstrates your product's value without being a sales pitch.

Example formats:

- "How I solved X problem" posts: Walk through a problem and your solution journey. Your product can be part of the solution you describe.
- Comparison posts: "I tried 5 tools for [problem]. Here's what I found." Include your product honestly alongside competitors.
- Tutorial posts: Teach something related to your product's domain. At the end, mention that your product simplifies this process.

- Data or research posts: Share interesting findings from your space. These get shared widely and establish your authority.

Here's a prompt to help you create this kind of content:

```
I've built a SaaS app that [describe app]. I want to write a helpful post for [specific community – e.g., r/webdev] that provides genuine value while naturally demonstrating why my product exists.
```

The post should:

- Start with a common problem or question the community faces
- Provide a thorough, helpful answer with multiple approaches
- Naturally mention my product as one of the solutions
- Include other alternatives so it doesn't feel like an ad
- End with a question that invites discussion
- Be around 500–800 words
- Match the tone and style of [the community]

Guest Posting and Cross-Promotion

Beyond community engagement, guest posting on relevant blogs and newsletters can put you in front of established audiences.

How to find guest posting opportunities:

- Search "[your niche] guest post" or "[your niche] write for us"
- Look at where your competitors have been featured
- Reach out to newsletter writers and blog owners in your space
- Offer to write something valuable for their audience (not a product review — a genuinely useful article)

Cross-promotion works when you partner with non-competing products that share your audience. For example, if you've built an invoicing tool, you could cross-promote with a time-tracking tool. You mention them, they mention you — both audiences benefit.

Building Your Own Community

At some point, you might want to create your own community around your product or your niche. This is a powerful long-term strategy, but it requires consistent effort.

Options for community platforms:

Platform	Best For	Cost	Effort
Discord server	Technical communities, real-time chat	Free	Medium-High
Slack workspace	Professional communities	Free (limited)	Medium
Email newsletter	Content-first communities	Free-\$50/month	Medium
Circle.so	Premium, course-based communities	From \$39/month	Medium-High
Facebook Group	Non-technical audiences	Free	Medium

The "100 Users Who Love You" Philosophy

This concept, popularised by Paul Graham (co-founder of Y Combinator), says it's better to have 100 users who absolutely love your product than 10,000 who think it's "okay." Those 100 passionate users become your evangelists — they recommend you to friends, defend you in discussions, and give you the feedback you need to make the product even better.

Your community strategy should focus on finding and nurturing those first 100 passionate users. They're worth more than any advertising campaign.

Offline Events and Meetups (Brief Mention)

While this module is focused on digital marketing, it's worth noting that offline events can be incredibly valuable for making connections that lead to online relationships:

- Local meetup groups (Meetup.com) — especially tech and startup meetups
- Hackathons — great for finding potential users and collaborators
- Conferences — even attending (not just speaking) puts you in rooms with potential users
- Co-working spaces — daily proximity to other builders creates natural networking

These don't need to be your primary strategy, but don't overlook them entirely. A single genuine conversation at a meetup can be worth more than a hundred online comments.

Tracking Community Marketing Efforts

Unlike paid advertising, community marketing is harder to measure directly. But you can still track its impact:

Metric	How to Track	What It Tells You
Referral traffic from communities	UTM links + Google Analytics	Which communities send the most visitors
"How did you hear about us?" responses	Onboarding survey question	Direct attribution to community efforts
Community mentions	Manual search or tools like Mention	How often your product comes up organically
Direct messages and inquiries	Track manually	Quality of interest from community engagement

A Practical Community Engagement Plan

Here's what a realistic weekly community engagement schedule looks like. This should take about 3-5 hours per week:

Monday: Check your top 3 communities. Answer 2-3 questions. Share one useful resource.

Wednesday: Write and post one piece of helpful content in your most active community.

Friday: Engage with other people's posts — comment, share, provide feedback. Check for any questions where your product is directly relevant.

That's it. Consistency trumps intensity. Showing up reliably every week builds your reputation far more effectively than occasional bursts of activity.

Using AI to Research Communities and Plan Engagement

Identify 15 online communities (Discord servers, Reddit subreddits, Slack groups, forums, and Facebook groups) where users of [describe your app's target audience and the problem your app solves] hang out.

For each community, provide:

1. Platform and name
 2. Approximate size/activity level
 3. Primary topics discussed
 4. Self-promotion rules (strict, moderate, or relaxed)
 5. A value-first engagement strategy specific to that community
 6. A sample helpful post or comment I could make there
-

Key Takeaways

- Go where your users already are. Don't try to build an audience from scratch when thousands of your potential users are already congregating in online communities.
- Provide value first, always. The give, give, give, ask model works. Become a helpful, trusted member of a community before you ever mention your product.
- Discord, Slack, Reddit, forums, and Facebook Groups are all potential goldmines. Identify which ones your specific target audience uses most actively.
- Build a reputation before you promote. Spend at least 2-4 weeks being genuinely helpful in a community before mentioning your product.
- Create content that naturally demonstrates your product's value. "How I solved X" posts, comparisons, and tutorials work much better than direct product announcements.
- Consider building your own community once you have traction. A Discord server, newsletter, or group can become a powerful long-term asset.

- Focus on finding 100 users who love you rather than 10,000 who are indifferent. Passionate early users are your most valuable marketing asset.
- Track your efforts. Use UTM links, onboarding surveys, and manual tracking to understand which communities drive the most valuable users.
- Consistency beats intensity. Spending 3-5 hours per week engaging reliably across a few communities is far more effective than sporadic bursts of activity.
- Be transparent. When you mention your product, always disclose that you're the founder. Communities respect honesty and punish deception.

Set Up an Affiliate Program

Think of your happiest customers. The ones who genuinely love your product, who tell their friends about it at dinner parties, who tweet about it without being asked. Now imagine you could give each of those people a unique tracking link and say: "Every time someone signs up through your link, you earn a commission." You've just turned your most passionate users into a motivated sales force — and you only pay them when they deliver results.

That's the essence of an affiliate program. It's word of mouth, systematised and scaled. And for SaaS products, it's one of the most efficient growth channels available because you pay nothing upfront. Every pound or dollar you spend on affiliate commissions is tied directly to a paying customer who already signed up. There's no wasted ad spend, no "hoping the campaign works." Someone signed up, they're paying, and now you share a portion of that revenue with the person who sent them your way.

In this section, we'll cover what affiliate programs are, how to design one that works for your SaaS product, which platforms make it easy to set up, how to recruit affiliates, and how to avoid common pitfalls.

What Is an Affiliate Program and How Does It Work?

An affiliate program is a marketing arrangement where you pay a commission to third parties (affiliates) for driving customers to your product. The mechanics are straightforward:

1. You create the program with a defined commission structure
2. Affiliates sign up and receive a unique tracking link or referral code
3. Affiliates share your product with their audience through blog posts, videos, social media, email newsletters, or direct recommendations
4. A potential customer clicks the affiliate's link and signs up for your product
5. The tracking system attributes the sign-up to that specific affiliate
6. You pay the affiliate a commission based on the terms you've set

The beauty of this model is alignment of incentives. The affiliate only earns money when they drive a real, paying customer. You only spend money when you acquire a real, paying customer. Everyone wins.

Why Affiliate Programs Work Especially Well for SaaS

SaaS products have characteristics that make affiliate programs particularly effective:

Recurring revenue means recurring commissions: If you offer recurring commissions (a percentage of each monthly payment, not just the first one), affiliates are motivated to send you customers who stick around. This naturally selects for higher-quality referrals.

Digital delivery means instant tracking: Unlike physical products where tracking gets complicated with shipping and returns, SaaS sign-ups happen instantly online and are easy to track and attribute.

High customer lifetime value (LTV): SaaS customers often pay for months or years. This means you can afford to pay generous commissions while still being profitable on each customer.

Easy to try: Most SaaS products offer free trials or freemium tiers. This makes it easier for affiliates to recommend your product because there's no risk for the person they're recommending it to.

Choosing Your Commission Structure

This is one of the most important decisions you'll make. Your commission structure needs to be attractive enough to motivate affiliates but sustainable enough that you remain profitable.

Here are the main approaches:

One-Time Commission

The affiliate earns a single payment when a customer signs up. Simple, predictable, and easy to manage.

Example: Your product costs \$29/month. You pay a one-time \$50 commission per new paying customer.

Pros: Easy to calculate costs, predictable expenses

Cons: Affiliates have less incentive to send you long-term customers

Recurring Commission

The affiliate earns a percentage of the customer's payment every month (or billing cycle) for as long as the customer remains subscribed.

Example: Your product costs \$29/month. You pay 20% recurring commission — the affiliate earns \$5.80 per month for each customer they referred, for as long as that customer keeps paying.

Pros: Strongly motivates affiliates to find quality customers who stay. Builds long-term partnerships.

Cons: Commission costs grow over time as referred customers accumulate.

Hybrid Model

A combination — a larger one-time payment plus a smaller recurring commission.

Example: \$25 one-time bonus + 10% recurring commission.

Pros: Immediate reward plus ongoing motivation

Cons: More complex to manage and communicate

Commission Comparison Table

Structure	Example (\$29/month product)	Affiliate Earnings (Year 1 per customer)	Best For
One-time flat fee	\$50 per sign-up	\$50	Products with high volume, lower LTV Simple programs, easy to communicate Products with high retention, long LTV Balance between affiliate motivation and cost control Attracting affiliates who want immediate and long-term earnings
One-time percentage	100% of first month (\$29)	\$29	
Recurring percentage	20% ongoing (\$5.80/month)	\$69.60	
Recurring with cap	20% for 12 months	\$69.60 (capped)	
Hybrid	\$25 + 10% ongoing	\$59.80	

What Commission Rate Should You Choose?

A common range for SaaS affiliate programs is 15% to 30% recurring or \$20 to \$100 one-time per customer. The right number depends on:

- Your profit margins: Make sure you're still profitable after the commission
- Customer lifetime value: If your average customer stays for 18 months at \$29/month (\$522 total), a 20% commission (\$104.40 over the lifetime) is very reasonable
- Competitor programs: Check what similar products offer. You don't need to be the highest, but being competitive helps

Here's a prompt to help you figure out the right structure:

```
Help me design an affiliate program for my SaaS product.
Here are the details:
- Monthly subscription price: $29/month
- Annual subscription price: $290/year
- Average customer stays for [X] months
- My approximate profit margin per customer is [X]%
- Competitor affiliate programs offer [describe if known]

Suggest:
1. The best commission structure (one-time, recurring, or hybrid)
2. Specific commission rates with reasoning
3. Cookie duration (how long after clicking the link does the
  affiliate get credit?)
4. Payment terms (when and how affiliates get paid)
5. Any special bonuses for top-performing affiliates
```

Affiliate Platforms: Making It Easy to Set Up

You could theoretically build an affiliate tracking system yourself using referral codes and database queries. But unless tracking and attribution is your core business, you're much better off using a dedicated platform. These tools handle tracking, attribution, payouts, and reporting so you can focus on growing your product.

Here's a comparison of the most popular affiliate platforms for SaaS:

Platform	Starting Price	Best For	Key Features	Ease of Setup
Rewardful	\$49/month	Stripe-based SaaS	Deep Stripe integration, simple setup, recurring commission tracking	Very Easy
FirstPromoter	\$49/month	SaaS with Stripe/Paddle	Full partner management, automated payouts, ecosystem	Easy
PartnerStack	Custom pricing	Mid to large SaaS	Multiple language support, commission tiers	Medium
Tapiliate	\$89/month	E-commerce and SaaS	Marketplace for affiliates and partners, strong integration	Medium
Refersion	\$99/month	E-commerce (some SaaS)	Affiliates built into payment system, no separate tool needed	Medium
Tolt	\$29/month	Early-stage SaaS	Affiliates built into payment system, no separate tool needed	Very Easy
Lemon Squeezy	Built-in (payment platform)	Digital products and SaaS	Affiliates built into payment system, no separate tool needed	Very Easy

Which Platform Should You Choose?

For most readers of this platform who are building SaaS products with Stripe, Rewardful or Tolt are excellent starting points. They integrate directly with Stripe (which you're likely already using for payments) and can be set up in under an hour. As your program grows, you might graduate to something more feature-rich like FirstPromoter or PartnerStack.

If you're using Lemon Squeezy for payments instead of Stripe, affiliate tracking is already built into their platform — one less thing to worry about.

The DIY Approach (Free but Limited)

If you're not ready for a paid platform, you can start with a manual approach:

- 1. Create unique discount codes for each affiliate (e.g., "ALEX20", "SARAH20")
- 2. Track code usage in your Stripe dashboard or database
- 3. Calculate commissions manually each month
- 4. Pay affiliates via PayPal, bank transfer, or Wise

This works fine for a handful of affiliates but becomes unmanageable as your program grows. Think of it as a prototype — use it to validate that affiliate marketing works for your product, then upgrade to a proper platform.

Setting Up Tracking Properly

Accurate tracking is the backbone of any affiliate program. If affiliates don't trust that their referrals are being properly tracked and credited, they won't promote your product.

Cookie duration: When someone clicks an affiliate link, a tracking cookie is stored in their browser. If they come back and sign up days later, the cookie ensures the affiliate still gets credit. Industry standard is 30 to 90 days. Shorter durations (7 days) can frustrate affiliates because not everyone signs up immediately.

UTM parameters: In addition to your affiliate platform's tracking, use UTM parameters to see affiliate traffic in your analytics:

```
https://yourapp.com?  
utm_source=affiliate&utm_medium=referral&utm_campaign=affiliate_name
```

Attribution models: Most affiliate programs use "last click" attribution — the last affiliate link clicked before sign-up gets the credit. This is the simplest and most common approach.

Creating Resources for Your Affiliates

Happy, productive affiliates need resources. The easier you make it for them to promote your product, the more they'll do it.

An affiliate resource kit should include:

- Product description: Short (1 sentence), medium (1 paragraph), and long (3 paragraphs)
- Key selling points: 5-7 bullet points explaining why your product is valuable
- Banner images: Multiple sizes (728x90, 300x250, 160x600) for websites
- Social media graphics: Optimised for Twitter, LinkedIn, Instagram, Facebook
- Email copy: Pre-written email templates affiliates can customise and send to their lists
- Demo video: A short walkthrough they can embed or share
- Comparison content: How your product compares to alternatives (give them the talking points)
- FAQ: Common questions potential customers ask, with answers

Here's a prompt to create your affiliate kit:

```
Help me create an affiliate resource kit for my SaaS product  
[describe product, price, target audience]. Generate:
```

1. Three product descriptions (1 sentence, 1 paragraph, 3 paragraphs)
2. 7 key selling points as bullet points
3. 5 email subject lines affiliates could use
4. A pre-written email template (3 paragraphs) affiliates can customise for their audience
5. 5 social media posts (mix of Twitter, LinkedIn, and Instagram) affiliates can use or adapt
6. Answers to the 5 most common objections potential customers might have
7. A comparison table showing our product vs [top 2-3 competitors]

Recruiting Affiliates

The best affiliate program in the world is useless without affiliates. Here's how to recruit them:

Your Existing Users (Best Source)

Your happiest customers are your best potential affiliates. They already know and love your product, which means their recommendations will be genuine and persuasive.

- Add an "Earn with us" or "Refer a friend" link in your app's navigation or footer
- Email your user base about the affiliate program when you launch it
- Identify your most active users and reach out personally with an invitation to join the program

Bloggers and Content Creators

People who write "best tools for X" or "top 10 Y tools" articles are natural affiliates. They're already creating content that compares and recommends products.

Search for:

- "Best [your category] tools 2026"
- "[Competitor name] alternatives"
- "Top [your niche] software"

Reach out to the authors of these articles and offer them an affiliate partnership. Many are already monetising through affiliate programs and will be happy to include your product.

YouTube Reviewers

Similar to bloggers, but in video format. YouTube creators who review tools in your category can drive significant affiliate revenue.

Comparison and Review Sites

Websites like G2, Capterra, and TrustRadius are often visited by people comparing products. While these are review sites rather than affiliate sites, getting listed and well-reviewed on them drives organic discovery.

Affiliate Networks and Marketplaces

Some affiliate platforms (like PartnerStack) have marketplaces where affiliates browse and apply to programs. Listing your program there provides passive affiliate recruitment.

Terms and Conditions Basics

Your affiliate program needs clear terms. While you should consult a legal professional for your specific situation, here are the standard elements:

- Commission rates and structure: Clearly state how much and when affiliates earn
- Cookie duration: How long referrals are tracked after a click
- Payment schedule: When and how commissions are paid (monthly, minimum threshold)

- Prohibited activities: No spam, no misleading ads, no bidding on your brand name in Google Ads
- Termination clause: You can terminate the relationship if terms are violated
- Attribution rules: How overlapping referrals are handled

Fraud Prevention

Unfortunately, some people try to game affiliate programs. Here are common fraud tactics and how to prevent them:

Fraud Type	How It Works	Prevention
Self-referral	Affiliate signs up through their own link	Block same-IP/email sign-ups, review suspicious patterns
Cookie stuffing	Loading tracking cookies without genuine clicks	Use reputable affiliate platforms with fraud detection
Fake sign-ups	Creating fake accounts to earn commissions	Require payment verification before paying commission
Brand bidding	Running Google Ads on your brand name to intercept traffic	Explicitly prohibit in terms, monitor with Google Alerts
Coupon sites	Posting your affiliate discount code on coupon aggregators	Restrict where codes can be shared, use unique links instead

Most reputable affiliate platforms include built-in fraud detection. Additionally, setting a minimum payout threshold (e.g., \$50 before first payout) and a commission holding period (e.g., commissions are payable 30 days after the customer's first payment) helps filter out fraudulent activity.

Measuring Your Affiliate Program's Success

Track these metrics monthly to understand whether your affiliate program is healthy:

Metric	What It Tells You	Healthy Range
Number of active affiliates	How many affiliates are actually promoting you	Growing month-over-month
Click-through rate	How compelling the affiliate's promotion is	1-5% of impressions
Conversion rate	How well your landing page converts affiliate traffic	2-10% of clicks
Revenue per affiliate	Average revenue generated per active affiliate	Varies by niche
Customer quality	Do affiliate-referred customers retain as well as organic ones?	Similar or better than average
Commission as % of revenue	How much of your revenue goes to affiliate payouts	15-30% is typical
Top affiliate concentration	Is one affiliate driving most of your affiliate revenue?	Diversified is healthier

Building a Landing Page for Potential Affiliates

You need a page on your website that explains your affiliate program and makes it easy to sign up. This page should include:

- What the program is (1-2 sentences)

- Commission structure (clear, specific numbers)
- Cookie duration
- Who it's for (bloggers, creators, existing users, etc.)
- What resources you provide (banners, copy, etc.)
- Testimonials from existing affiliates (once you have them)
- Sign-up form or link to your affiliate platform

Help me design an affiliate program landing page for my SaaS. Monthly subscription is \$29/month. I'm offering 25% recurring commission with a 60-day cookie window.

Create:

1. A compelling headline and subheadline
2. Three bullet points explaining why someone should become an affiliate
3. A clear breakdown of the commission structure with examples (e.g., "Refer 10 customers and earn \$72.50/month, every month")
4. A FAQ section with 5 common questions and answers
5. A call-to-action section encouraging sign-up
6. Suggested page layout and sections in order

Getting Started: A Step-by-Step Plan

Here's a practical roadmap for launching your affiliate program:

Week 1: Design

- Decide on your commission structure
- Choose an affiliate platform
- Write your terms and conditions

Week 2: Build

- Set up the affiliate platform and connect to your payment system (Stripe)
- Create your affiliate landing page
- Prepare your affiliate resource kit (descriptions, images, email templates)

Week 3: Soft Launch

- Email your existing users about the program
- Personally invite your 5-10 happiest customers
- Add "Affiliate" or "Earn with us" link to your website footer

Week 4+: Grow

- Reach out to bloggers and content creators in your space

- Optimise your affiliate landing page based on sign-up data
 - Support your affiliates with fresh resources and promotional ideas
 - Celebrate and share affiliate success stories
-

Key Takeaways

- Affiliate programs let you pay for results, not promises. You only spend money when an affiliate drives a real, paying customer. This makes it one of the most cost-efficient marketing channels.
- Recurring commissions attract better affiliates. Offering 20-30% recurring commission motivates affiliates to send you quality customers who stick around, because their earnings grow over time.
- Use a dedicated platform for tracking. Rewardful, Tolt, and FirstPromoter are excellent for Stripe-based SaaS products. Manual tracking works for a handful of affiliates but doesn't scale.
- Your existing users are your best potential affiliates. They already love your product and can recommend it authentically. Make it easy for them to sign up and share.
- Create a comprehensive resource kit. Give affiliates descriptions, images, email templates, and social media copy. The easier you make it for them to promote you, the more they will.
- Set clear terms and prevent fraud. Define commission rates, cookie duration, prohibited activities, and payment schedules. Use holding periods and minimum thresholds to deter bad actors.
- Measure and optimise continuously. Track active affiliates, conversion rates, revenue per affiliate, and customer quality. A healthy program should show steady growth across these metrics.
- Start simple and iterate. You don't need a perfect program on day one. Launch with a few happy customers as affiliates, learn what works, and expand from there.